

ATS Handbook

1. What Is an ATS and How It Parses Resumes

An Applicant Tracking System (ATS) is software that companies use to collect, parse, filter, and rank job applications before a human ever opens them. When you submit a resume, the ATS extracts the raw text, attempts to classify it into fields (name, contact info, job titles, dates, skills), and stores that structured data so recruiters can search and filter candidates by keyword, years of experience, or education.

Parsing accuracy depends heavily on how the document is built. Most modern ATS platforms (Workday, Greenhouse, Lever, iCIMS, Taleo) use a text-extraction layer similar to a PDF-to-text converter, reading content in the order it appears in the underlying document structure rather than the order it visually appears on the page. This is why layout choices that look fine to a human eye can still parse incorrectly.

A resume that an ATS cannot parse correctly may be marked as missing required fields (such as job titles or dates) and ranked lower, or in some configurations, effectively hidden from recruiter search results even though a human would have found it well-qualified.

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2. ATS-Friendly Formatting Rules

Use a single-column layout. Multi-column resumes are the single most common cause of scrambled ATS parsing, because most parsers read left-to-right, top-to-bottom across the full page width, which interleaves the two columns' content into a nonsensical order.

Avoid placing content inside text boxes, tables, or embedded graphics — many parsing engines skip these elements entirely, silently deleting your work experience or skills from the extracted text. Similarly, avoid headers and footers for anything essential like your name or contact details, since some parsers ignore header/footer regions.

Use standard section headings that the ATS's field-classifier expects: 'Work Experience' or 'Experience' (not 'Where I've Made an Impact'), 'Education', 'Skills'. Creative or unconventional headings reduce the odds that the parser correctly labels the section. Stick to standard fonts (Arial, Calibri, Helvetica, Times New Roman) since custom or decorative fonts can produce garbled character extraction in some parsers.

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3. Keyword Optimization Strategies

Most ATS platforms rank or filter candidates by matching keywords from the job description against the resume text. Read the target job posting and extract the specific hard skills, tools, and certifications it lists (for example: Node.js, PostgreSQL, Docker, Kubernetes, AWS, REST APIs), then ensure those exact terms appear in your resume if you genuinely have that experience — do not fabricate skills you do not have.

Include both the acronym and the spelled-out form of important terms at least once (for example 'Application Programming Interface (API)' or 'Amazon Web Services (AWS)'), since some ATS keyword matches are exact-string and you cannot predict which form a recruiter's search will use.

Place a dedicated 'Skills' section near the top of the resume listing your core technical skills as a simple comma-separated or bulleted list — this gives the ATS an unambiguous, easy-to-parse block of keywords in addition to skills that appear naturally within your experience bullets.

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4. File Format and Naming Best Practices

Submit your resume as a standard, text-based PDF unless the application specifically requests a .docx file. A text-based PDF (created by exporting from a word processor, not by scanning a printed page) preserves selectable, searchable text that ATS parsers can extract reliably; a scanned image or a PDF built from a design tool that flattens text into vector shapes will often extract as blank or garbled text.

Name your file descriptively and professionally, such as 'FirstName-LastName-Resume.pdf', rather than a generic name like 'resume_final_v3.pdf' or 'Document1.pdf'. Some recruiter workflows display the filename directly, and a clear name looks more professional and organized.

Avoid password-protecting or restricting your resume file in any way, since automated parsers cannot open protected documents and your application may be silently dropped.

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5. Testing Your Resume Against ATS

A simple manual test: copy all the text out of your PDF and paste it into a plain text editor. If the resulting text reads in a sensible, logical order with all your experience and skills intact, your document structure is likely ATS-safe. If the pasted text is jumbled, missing sections, or has broken words, your layout needs simplification.

Check that every job title, company name, and date range appears as plain, extractable text — not embedded inside an image, icon, or decorative graphic element. Dates should use a consistent, unambiguous format such as 'Jan 2022 – Present' throughout the document.

As a final check, confirm your document has no more than one font family, no tables or columns, and that the Skills section explicitly lists the key technologies from the job description you are applying to, in addition to their natural use within your experience section.